

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 16



CHAPTER 16



A SIMPLE MATTER OF MATHEMATICS

On the evening of the tenth day they fought their way clear of Sunda Strait and anchored.

Prince called Nat to his cabin. He had a chart spread before him. "Well, Mr. Bowditch," he growled, "what do you think of the Dutch East Indies in general and Sunda Strait in particular?"

Nat looked at the chart. "I'm dumfounded," he admitted. "I've always thought of an island as — you know — small. I thought when we got to the East Indies we'd be just a stone's throw from anywhere in them. When it

finally dawns on you — the size of them! Three thousand islands — over seven hundred thousand square miles — it's amazing, isn't it? Take Java, now. It looks small on a map, but it's several times as big as Massachusetts. A man certainly gets new ideas when he — ”

Prince slapped his hands flat on the table, stood and roared, “You *mathematician!* Is that all you have to say about Sunda Strait?”

“Oh . . . the Strait? I'd say it would be better to make your passage out in ballast. Just carry specie and buy your cargo in Manila. The higher we ride, the more chance we have of catching the wind. It's — ”

Prince glared. "You say it's a 'simple matter of mathematics' and I'll brain you!" He sat down and studied the chart. "Now, to the next problem. Heaven knows how much we can depend on this chart. It's something over fifteen hundred miles to Manila. And what's between here and there . . ." He shrugged.

"At least we know the latitude and longitude of Manila," Nat said. "We can set our course for it as directly as . . ." He looked at the chart. "As directly as islands, straits, and reefs let us, can't we?"

Prince muttered something under his breath. "That's all, Mr. Bowditch."

On Saturday, the first of October, Nat went to Prince's cabin. "We should anchor in Manila Bay tomorrow, sir."

Prince stared at him long and hard. Suddenly he smiled. "That so, Mr. Bowditch? Manila tomorrow, eh? I'd better lay out my go-ashore clothes."

Nat shook his head. "I doubt if we'll need go-ashore clothes tomorrow, sir. I understand Manila Harbor's one of the biggest land-locked harbors in the world. More than seven hundred square miles. So we —"

Prince roared, "You —*mathematician!*"

Nat said, "Aye. aye, sir," and went topside. What in the name of sense, he wondered, had set Prince roaring that time? Manila Harbor was one of the biggest land-locked harbors in the world.

The next morning they were standing off Luzon. A pilot came aboard, sternly ordered all men out of the chains — no sounding of the harbor was allowed — and conducted them to their anchorage.

Nearby, another ship flew the stars and stripes. No sooner were they anchored than the ship hailed them, and the master, Captain Riddle, came aboard.

“From Salem, eh? Three cheers! You’re the first Salem ship ever to enter Manila Harbor! How was it around the Horn?”

Prince said, “We came by the Cape and Sunda Strait. The Cape’s not so bad — but I can’t recommend Sunda Strait. We spent ten days getting through it — from the eighth to the seventeenth of September.”

"You came from Sunda Strait since the seventeenth? In fifteen days?" Riddle asked. "Man alive, that's navigation!"

Captain Prince shrugged. "Not when you're sure of your longitude. Just a simple matter of mathematics. You . . ." He stopped, and glared at Nat.

"Captain Riddle, sir, have you ever seen a boat like this before?" Nat asked quickly, pointing to a canoe.

The three stood at the rail and watched the long, slim craft, carved from one log, with a huge sail woven of matting. The crew of eight dark-skinned, laughing natives looked as though they had not a care in the world.

“That canoe isn’t big enough to carry a flying jib,” Nat said. “But look at that sail! It must be a thousand square feet!”

“The canoe is an outrigger,” said Captain Riddle. “See those bamboo logs athwart the boat, fore and aft,

sticking out over the water, with the other logs joining their ends?”

“Yes, but I thought that must be cargo — something too big to get into the canoe. You mean they’re fastened on the canoe?” Nat asked incredulously. “They’re — ”

A sudden gust of wind caught the huge sail, and the canoe heeled over, throwing up a spray of water.

"There she goes!" Nat yelled.

But six of the laughing brown men slid out on the bamboo logs on the windward side, and their weight balanced the huge sail against the pressure of the wind. The canoe righted itself and sped through the water.

Captain Prince pursed his lips in a silent whistle.

"That's something I'll tell — " Nat stopped, as Prince looked at him.

Several times during their weeks at Manila Nat felt Captain Prince's thoughtful stare on the back of his neck. In December, when they weighed anchor for home, the captain drawled, "Well, Mr. Bowditch, you'll have a lot to tell her — your sister, I mean — won't you?"

"Aye, aye, sir." And Nat remembered something he had to see about right away.

What was Elizabeth doing now, he wondered, half-way around the world? That night he began to jot notes of all he would tell her — and what he would leave out. The earthquake in Manila — he'd better skip that — or should he? Would she hear about it from someone else and be worried?

Week after week, as he stood his watches and taught the crew with one part of his mind, another part of it seemed busy checking off the miles — and the months — between him and Elizabeth.

At dawn one February morning, when they were in the Indian Ocean, the lookout's cry gave warning, "Sail ho-o-o-o-o-o! On the starboard bow!"

On the heels of the cry came Lem's bellow, "Loose your guns!"

Long before the ship was near enough for the lookout to see her colors, the *Astrea* was ready for action.

When the lookout yelled, "She's American!" Lem Harvey growled, "Secure your guns!"

The ship was the *Stanley*, from Boston, Captain Daniels commanding. Captain Daniels gave them news of home. Grim news. America was at war with France. Not declared yet, he said, when he sailed, but doubtless it was declared by now. The French were sinking American ships left and right.

"Keep your guns shotted and your powder dry!" Those were the parting words he bellowed through his trumpet.

From then on, Nat could feel the tension in the air. He knew the lookouts strained their eyes as never before, sweeping the horizon for an enemy sail. He knew that many a man turned in all standing, ready for instant action. He knew he slept with one ear cocked for the pell-mell thud of feet overhead, and the cry, "All hands on deck!"

deck.

It was the middle of a peaceful dog watch when danger struck. There was not a sail on the horizon, or a storm cloud in the sky; just a fair wind abaft the beam and the *Astrea* reaching for the Cape. Tom Owens stumbled up a companionway yelling, "We've sprung a leak!"

Lem Harvey was the first man at the pumps.

Nat heard him growl, "Why couldn't it have been something simple — like a fight!" He knew what Lem meant. A bad leak was something you couldn't conquer with a broadside from your guns. Even if it didn't drive them to a long delay in a foreign port, it would be with

them every league of the way to Salem Harbor. They'd be short-handed at all other work. Men would be needed at the pumps, night and day.

As the weeks passed, they held their own against the leak — but no more. At last they loaded the deep-sea lead, sounded — and brought up black mud! They were off Block Island!

“We'll make it!” Tom Owens roared.

Lem growled, “There's many a reef between Block and Baker's Island!”

But the *Astrea* plowed on. Sand in the deep-sea lead now. They were off Nantucket.

Tom grinned. "How about it, Lem?"

"I'd like a dollar for every ship that's gone aground between here and Baker's Island," Lem growled.

At dawn one morning late in May came the lookout's, "Land ho-o-o-o-o!" They had sighted Cape Ann. The thought flicked through Nat's head, They're too tired to cheer. I know I am. Then a hoarse roar split the air and fairly shook the rigging, and Nat found he was yelling, too.

Captain Prince was on deck now, grim-jawed, alert. Danger was not over when they sighted Cape Ann. Still six hours ahead of them, at the speed they were making. Six hours, and one miscalculation could wreck a ship in sight of home.

Gales Ledge to starboard . . . Pilgrim Ledge . . . how many ships had been wrecked within a stone's throw of

home . . . Whaleback to starboard . . . A good berth now to the northwest point of Baker's Island . . . Midchannel now between Baker's Island and Little Misery . . . Captain Prince was keeping Naugus Head and Coney Island in line now . . . a narrow lane of safety . . . Hardy's Rocks and Rising States Ledge and the shoals of Eagle Island on the south; on the north, Bowditch Ledge.

When he was young, Nat remembered, he had felt proud of a ledge named Bowditch. Later he learned that having a ledge named for you or your ship meant disaster instead of honor.

Bowditch Ledge astern to the north of them . . .

Thoughts of home filled Nat's head, mixed with his thoughts of the channel they were following. Was Dr. Bentley on his lookout now? Had he sighted the *Astrea*? Was his flag whipping in the breeze, giving the news to the town? West by north now, to give a good berth to the Haste . . . Was Elizabeth on the captain's walk, watching for the *Astrea*? What was she thinking about? Was she remembering their good-by? Or had she forgotten? Nat could feel his heart pounding. Over the roar of blood in his ears, he heard Prince's voice, "Southwest by south."

The helmsman answered, "Aye, aye, sir; southwest by south."

. Abbot Rock to starboard now . . . The shoals of Middle Ground to larboard . . . Would Elizabeth be on the wharf when they anchored? Of course she wouldn't, Nat told himself. He'd rather she wouldn't be. All that crowd and confusion . . . everyone talking at the same time . . . wives greeting their husbands . . . mothers looking for their sons . . . Every Tom, Dick, and Harry there, wanting to know about his venture. She wouldn't be there . . .

Elizabeth was the first person he saw when he reached the wharf . . . Elizabeth, standing on something to see over the crowd, and smiling and waving. Somehow he wormed his way through the crowd to reach her.

"Nat!" Elizabeth called. "We've been waiting for *hours!*"

A man's voice said, "Seems like *days!*"

Nat saw the man with her then — a tall, handsome chap, with dark hair sweeping back in a widow's peak and smiling dark eyes.

The young man said, "I don't suppose you remember me, Mr. Bowditch. I haven't been around Salem much for years. I was knee high to a grasshopper when I went to Harvard."

Nat shook hands and smiled and called David Farrel by name. He said of course he remembered him, it was fine to see him again.

“It’s good to see you, too, sir!” David told him. “Elizabeth talks so much about you. Like you were her big brother — or something. Almost like you were her father!”

Of course, Nat thought. He should have known. She was seventeen. He was twenty-four. Just a simple matter of mathematics, Mr. Bowditch! he told himself grimly. You should have figured that one out!